

Session 22: Abraham's Covenant with Abimelech

Key Takeaways

- The biblical authors place these two episodes alongside each other, strongly linked with key words and themes, in order to highlight their differences.
- The family of God can act arrogantly about their chosen status, driving the nations away, or they can, through covenant, reconcile and live together in peace and blessing.
- The line of the chosen has a specific purpose that doesn't have to do with whether they're righteous or not—it has to do with the promise of the snake-crusher.
- Comparing literary units with each other is the Bible's way of being its own commentary, leading us to deeper layers of meaning.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 21:14-21

¹⁴ And Avraham rose early in the morning,
and he took bread and a **skin of water** ,
and he gave to Hagar,
placing upon her shoulder, and the **child** ,
and **he sent her away** (וישלחה),

and **she went** (ותלך)
and she wandered **in the wilderness** of **Beer-Sheva (= "Well of Seven ")**
¹⁵ and the **water finished from the skin** ,
and **she cast** (ותשלך) the **child** under one of the bushes,

¹⁶ and **she went** (ותלך)
and **she sat for herself a distance away** ,
going as far as people can **shoot a bow** ,
because she said,
" **I can't see** the death of the **child** ."
And **she sat a distance away** ,
and she lifted up **her voice** ,
and she wept.

¹⁷ And **Elohim heard the voice of the** **young boy** ,

and the messenger of Elohim called to Hagar from the skies,
and he said to her,

"What is it that concerns you, Hagar?

Don't be afraid,

because **Elohim has heard the voice of the young boy**, in the place where he is.

¹⁸ Get up, pick up the **young boy**,

and take him with your hand,

because **I will make him a nation, a great one (גדול).**"

¹⁹ And Elohim **opened her eyes**,

and she saw a **well of water**,

and **she went (ותלך)** and **she filled the skin of water**,

and she had the young one drink.

²⁰ And Elohim was with the **young boy**,

and **he grew big (גדל)** and **he dwelt in the wilderness**,

and he was a **shooter of the bow**.

²¹ and **he dwelt in the wilderness** of Paran.

And his mother took for him a wife from the land of Egypt.

Genesis 21:1-21. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

A Flood of Eden Water in the Desert

The echoes of the Eden and flood narratives in this story are subtle but powerful, and they set up important comparisons between these stories that give depth and insight into this episode.

Echoes of Eden Water

Creation of Eden	Re-Creation of Hagar and Yishmael
Begins with a lack of water: Gen. 2:5 "There weren't yet any bushes (שיח) in the land ... for Yahweh Elohim had not yet caused any rain upon the land."	Begins with a lack of water: Gen. 21:14-15 "And she wandered in the wilderness of Beer-Sheva, and the waters were finished from the water skin, so she cast the child under one of the bushes (שיח)."
Gen. 2:6 "But a stream would come up out of the land and it would provide water (והשקה) for all the face of the land."	Gen. 21:19 "And she saw a well of water, and she went and filled the water skin and she provided water (ותשק) for the child."

Echoes of Eden Water. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Creation of Eden	Re-Creation of Hagar and Yishmael
Gen. 2:24 "And a man will leave his father and mother and become joined to his wife ..."	Gen. 21:21 "And his mother took for him a wife from the land of Egypt."
<i>Echoes of Eden Water.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).	

God provides life-giving water for Hagar and Yishmael in the waterless desert by means of a “well of seven,” which leads to the provision of a wife for the son. This sequence maps onto both the first and last moments of the opening movement of the Eden narrative, which also begins with God’s provision of water in the wilderness (Gen. 2:4-6) and concludes with the provision of a wife (Gen. 2:24).

The point here is that God provides an “Eden blessing” for the non-chosen son separate from the chosen line in the promised land.

Floodwater Images

The Flood	Hagar and Yishmael in the Wilderness
Gen. 8:2 And the rain was restrained (ויכלא) from the skies. Gen. 8:5 And the waters were continually (היו הלוד) decreasing.	Gen. 21:15 And the waters were finished (ויכלו) from the water skin.
Gen. 9:1 And Elohim blessed Noah saying, "Be fruitful and multiply (רבה) ." Gen. 9:12-15 "This is the sign of the covenant ... between me and you and every living creature ... I have set my bow (קשת) in the skies ... never again will the waters become a flood, and the bow (קשת) I will see, to remember the eternal covenant."	Gen. 21:16 And she cast the child under one of the bushes and she went and sat as far as the shot of a bow (קשת) . Gen. 21:20 And the young boy grew up and dwelt in the wilderness and he was a shooter of a bow (קשת רבה) .
<i>Floodwater Images.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).	

Noah and his family are rescued from the flood of too much water and given a covenant sign of the bow to remember God’s promise. Hagar and Yishmael are rescued from not having any water and given protection and promise. The words “bow” and “multiply” are homonyms in Hebrew, different words spelled with the same letters, and this is a key linking word that ties the two narratives together.

Avraham Loses His Firstborn Son ... First

This story and the following story of the binding of Yitskhaq in [Genesis 22](#) are the narrative culminations of Avraham's many failed tests. The sin of Avraham and Sarah against Hagar that began in [Genesis 16](#) has created a conflict that has boiled over in [chapter 21](#). And while God allows them to expel Hagar and her son, the expulsion is depicted on analogy to the near loss of Yitskhaq that will soon follow.

It's as if God is finally requiring of Avraham the consequences of his and Sarah's failures. The following list of parallels between the two stories shows a clearly intended analogy.

Genesis 21:8-21	Genesis 22:1-19
Gen. 21:12-13 God orders Yishmael and Hagar's expulsion	Gen. 22:1 God orders the sacrifice of Yitskhaq
Gen. 21:14 And Avraham woke early in the morning (וישכם אברהם בבקר).	Gen. 22:3 And Avraham woke early in the morning (וישכם אברהם בבקר).
Gen. 21:14 And he took (ויקח) bread and a skin of water and he gave to Hagar setting upon her shoulder (שם על שכמה).	Gen. 22:6 And Avraham took (ויקח) the wood of the burnt offering and he set upon (וישם על) Yitskhaq.
Gen. 21:15 And she cast the child under one of the bushes (תחת אחד השיחים).	Gen. 22:13 And behold, a ram behind (אחר) in the bush/thicket ... and he offered it in the place of (תחת) his son.
Gen. 21:16 And she sat far away (הרחק) ... for she said, "I will not look (ראה) upon the death of the child."	Gen. 22:4 And he saw (ראה) the place [of Yitskhaq's death] from afar (מרחק).
Gen. 21:17 And the angel of God called to Hagar from the heavens.	Gen. 22:11 And the angel of Yahweh called to him from the heavens.
Gen. 21:17 "Don't be afraid (ירא)."	Gen. 22:12 "Now I know that you fear (ירא) God."
Gen. 21:18a "Pick up the young man (הנער) and grab (חזק) him with your hand (ידך)."	Gen. 22:12-13 "Don't send out your hand (ידך) against the young man (הנער) ... a ram caught/grabbed (אחז) by the bush."
Gen. 21:18b "I will make him into a great nation."	Gen. 22:17 "Your offspring will be like the stars in

Avraham Loses His Firstborn Son. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Genesis 21:8-21	Genesis 22:1-19
	the sky and the dust of the land."
Gen. 21:19 And God opened her eyes and she saw a well of water.	Gen. 22:13 And Avraham lifted his eyes and saw, a ram caught in the bush by his horns.
Gen. 21:33 And he planted a tamarisk tree in Beersheba.	Gen. 22:19 And Avraham dwelt in Beersheba.
<i>Avraham Loses His Firstborn Son. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).</i>	

In both stories, God saves Avraham’s sons from the death that was set in motion by God’s own commands—first to expel Yishmael, second to offer Yitskhaq as a sacrifice.

Both crises are resolved by God providing a solution (water and a ram) at the last moment to a parent who has surrendered to the inevitability of death.

At each point, Avraham’s experience in [Genesis 22](#) is a reversal of Hagar’s experience with Yishmael.

In both stories, God is the one who allows/causes the loss of the son, and in both stories it is God who intervenes at the moment of crisis (an “angel of Yahweh calling from the skies”) to deliver the son from death.

In these two narratives, Avraham is forced to give up both of his sons to death, and in both he provides them with items that will play a role in their reversal from death: Yishmael with the skin bottle, and Yitskhaq with the wood on his back.

This tragic loss of Yishmael is a result of Avram and Sarai’s sin in [Genesis 16](#), resulting in a sibling rivalry pattern:

- Sarai and Hagar are rival wives angered over each other’s offspring.
- Yishmael and Yitskhaq are rival brothers. Like Qayin and Hevel/Seth, the firstborn will be banished to live in the wilderness, but unlike Qayin, the irrational anger belongs to Yitskhaq's mother.

This story pushes forward the paradoxical status of being the chosen son, which forces other brothers to reckon with their own non-chosen status, and which puts the chosen one in danger.

In the case of Yitskhaq, Yishmael’s story sets our expectations that Avraham will have to “give up” Yitskhaq too in some way. As in the story of Yishmael, it is precisely through the “giving over” of the promised son to death that the divine covenant purpose is fulfilled.

Both sons are appointed as carriers of a future legacy, though in this case their descendants will be rival kin living separated from each other.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 21:22-34

22 And it came about at that time,
that **Avimelek said, and Phikol, captain of his army**, to Avraham, saying,

"Elohim is with you in all that you are doing!

23 And now, **swear an oath (שבע)** to me by Elohim!

Look, if you deal falsely with me or my offspring or descendants ...

According to the loyal love that I have done to you,

so you will deal with me,

and with **the land that you have migrated within**."

24 And Avraham said,

"I will **swear an oath (שבע)**."

a 25 And Avraham disputed with Avimelek,

b on account of a **well of water**

a' that the servants of Avimelek had stolen.

26 And Avimelek said,

a **"I don't know who did this thing!**

b And also, you didn't report it to me!

a' And also, I never heard of it until today!"

27 And **Avraham** took sheep and oxen,

and he gave to **Avimelek**,

and **the two of them cut a covenant**.

28 And Avraham set up **seven (שבע)** female lambs of the flock alone,

29 and Avimelek said to Avraham,

"What are these **seven (שבע)** female lambs that you have set up alone?"

30 And he said,

"Because the **seven (שבע)** female lambs you will take from my hand,

so that it will become a **witness (עדה)** on my behalf,

that I dug this **well**."

a 31 For this reason, one calls that place **"Beer - Sheva"** [**Well** of **Seven (שבע)**]

b because there **the two of them swore an oath (שבע)**.

a' 32 And **they cut a covenant** at **Beer - Sheva**,

and **Avimelek got up, and Phikol the captain of his army**,

and they returned to **the land of the Philistines**,

³³ and he planted a tamarisk tree at Beer - Sheva ,
and he called on the name of Yahweh, El-eternal.

³⁴ And he was a migrant in the land of the Philistines for many days.

Genesis 21:22-34. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Rival Families Make Peace Through a Covenant

On the most basic level, the episode is designed in a three-step sequence, indicated by the narrative flow and by the repetition of key words. A simple plot analysis illuminates the basic dynamics of the story.

1. Conflict: The leaders of the Philistines feel threatened by God's blessing and invite Avraham to make a covenant of peace with them.
2. Conflict escalates: Avraham brings up the matter of a disputed well that further aggravates their conflict, and both matters are resolved through a covenant.
3. Resolution: After the two rivals are unified through a covenant, Avraham plants a tree and meets with Yahweh at the tree.

This is a story about two rival "brothers," each of whom feels threatened by the other. The Philistines recognize God's blessing on Avraham ("Elohim is with you in all that you do"), and instead of initiating conflict, they invite Avraham into a covenant of peace. This recalls the promise of [Genesis 12:1-3](#), which says, "Those who bless you will be blessed ... all the families of the land will find blessing by means of you."

Avraham, on the other hand, brings up a disputed matter about a water source in the wilderness. But here too, Avimelek shows himself favorable to Avraham as he confesses his ignorance about the well.

The result: The expected result when two rival families are in conflict over resources is violence, but in this case, the families achieve peace through just dealings that lead to a covenant of peace. The story ends with Eden imagery (Avraham meets with Yahweh under a tree he planted), showing matters have reached an ideal resolution.

Rival Tribes, Rival Brothers, and Wells of Seven

When we zoom out and see [Genesis 21:22-34](#) in a wider context, new elements of the story are highlighted and come into the foreground.

Genesis 20:1-18

A - Avraham and Avimelek: Conflict Caused by Deception

- Abe deceives Avi regarding his wife
- Avi is innocent of wrongdoing and returns Abe's wife
- Abe intercedes for the bound wombs of Avi's wives

Genesis 21:1-21

B - Avraham Loses His Son Yishmael, Whose Life Is Spared by God

- Yitskhaq is born
- Sarah and Yitskhaq separate from Hagar and Yishmael
- Avraham sends mother and son to die in wilderness
- God provides **water of life ("Well of Seven")** to save the endangered son
- God will make Yishmael into a great nation

Genesis 21:22-34

A' - Avraham and Avimelek: Conflict Resolved by Covenant

- Avi approaches Abe to make a covenant and **oath of loyalty at the well of seven**
- Avi is innocent of wrongdoing and returns to Abe's well
- Abe meets Yahweh at a sacred tree by the **Well of Seven**

Genesis 22:1-19

B' - Avraham Loses His Son Yitskhaq, Whose Life Is Spared by God

- Yitskhaq is about to die
- Sarah and Avraham are to separate from Yitskhaq
- Avraham is to give Yitskhaq over to death on Mount Moriah
- God provides a substitute ram to save the endangered son
- God will bless all nations through Avraham's seed
- Avraham retires with his son to the **Well of Seven**

Genesis 20:1-22:19 Symmetry. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

This group of stories is arranged in a forward symmetry that invites us to compare and contrast each one to the other for greater insight.

The two stories about Avraham and Avimelek in Genesis 20:1-18 and 21:22-34 have a remarkable number of similarities and important differences. Both stories begin with Avraham's presence in the land of the Philistines leading to some kind of conflict that is resolved through confession and covenant.

In Genesis 20, Avraham creates the conflict through deception about Sarah, and Avimelek innocently takes a woman that doesn't belong to him. God's chosen one ends up bringing a curse of infertility (i.e., death) onto the nations because of his sin.

In Genesis 21, Avimelek recognizes Avraham as God's chosen one and wants to share in God's blessing through him, so he makes a covenant. When Avraham mentions that Avimelek has stolen his well, Avimelek is ignorant and innocent, but he makes an overture to create peace. God's chosen one ends up sharing God's blessing with the nations through a covenant.

The two stories about the loss and recovery of Yishmael (Gen. 21:1-21) and Yitskhaq (Gen. 22:1-19) show a remarkable number of similarities and differences as well.

Both stories result in near death and surprising rescue of Avraham's sons, and both stories are the sad result of Avraham and Sarah's sin against Hagar in [Genesis 16](#).

In [Genesis 21](#), God allows Hagar to be expelled by Sarah, and Avraham sends the mother and son into the wilderness to die. But God, through a messenger, rescues the endangered son and provides water in the wilderness. The rescued son will be blessed and become a great nation.

In [Genesis 22](#), God tests Avraham by asking him to surrender Yitskhaq as a sacrifice. But God, through a messenger, rescues the endangered son by providing a substitute sacrifice. The rescued son will become a source of blessing for all other nations.

The two stories of conflict and rivalry in [Genesis 21:1-21](#) and [21:22-34](#) are both resolved at Beer-Sheva, the "Well of Seven."

In [Genesis 21:1-21](#), the rivalry between the wives and son leads to a near death in the wilderness because of no water. It is precisely the water that provides the transition from death to life.

In [Genesis 21:22-34](#), the exact same water becomes a source of rivalry that is resolved by a covenant of peace.

Sibling Rivalry Resolved in an Eden Place

The story of Avraham and Avimelek's conflict and covenant is also hyperlinked to the entire network of earlier stories about family rivalries that result in separation. And these rivalry stories are themselves rooted all the way back in the story of the splitting of the one human to become two.

Adam and Eve in the Garden

In the garden of Eden (גן עדן), the human is alone (לבדו), so God causes sleep to fall on the human so that one side (צלע) can be taken and built into another human, and now the two (שניהם) are meant to become one flesh (בשר אחד). The two of them (שניהם) are naked and have no shame.

Qayin and Hevel at the Door of Eden

At the door (פתח) of Eden, two brothers bring offering. The younger son is favored by God, and the elder son gets angry and murders God's chosen one, the younger sibling. Qayin, the non-chosen, is banished (גרש).

Noah's Sons in the Garden Tent

In the tent (אהל) in Noah's vineyard (כרם), while Noah is asleep from wine, the youngest son attempts to usurp the position of the older brothers through illicit sex. When he informs his older brothers, the two of them (שניהם) cover the shameful nakedness, and the father blesses the tent (אהל) of the middle son Shem, and the brothers separate (פרד).

Avraham and Lot in the Promised Land

Avraham and his nephew Lot are living in the promised land, but it cannot support them and their flocks living together as one (יחדו). There is a dispute (ריב) between the brothers, and Lot separates (פרד) from Avraham to go live in Sodom, which he considers to be like the garden (גן) of Eden.

Hagar and Yishmael

Sarah and Yitskhaq are the chosen ones, and in angry jealousy Sarah wants the non-chosen Hagar and Yishmael to be banished (גרש). They wander in the desert, where God provides Eden-like water for them.

Avraham and Avimelek

Avraham is approached by Avimelek at the Well of Seven (Beer-Sheva). There is a dispute (הוכח) over a well, and their conflict is resolved when the two of them (שניהם) make a covenant (ברית) by Avraham setting lambs "alone" (לבדהו). Then Avraham plants a sacred tree where he meets with Yahweh.

In [Genesis 2-3](#), it is precisely the splitting of the human to become more than one that creates the possibility of conflict. [Genesis 2:24](#) becomes an ideal portrait, when the two who are different from one another become one through covenant and live at peace, without shame.

The breakdown of the human family in Genesis 1-11 is a whole series of distortions of this ideal, as different people and families begin a cycle of rivalry, conflict, and separation.

- Adam and Eve at the tree
- Cain and Abel at the door of Eden
- Lemek in the city
- Noah's sons in the tent
- Avraham and Lot in the land

The story about Avraham and Avimelek in [Genesis 21](#) is a dramatic reversal of this theme. In this case, the nations recognize God's chosen one and decide to make peace through covenant so that they can share in God's blessing. When the dispute arises, we expect that violent conflict, or at least separation, will occur. But instead Avimelek makes an offer of covenantal peace, and Avraham is able to negotiate his dispute with the nations.

This story shows Avraham not only reversing his deception of Avimelek, but points forward to how the blessing of Avraham will be mediated to the nations through a covenant of peace.

But there is one more step in this section of stories that contributes to this theme of blessing for the nations. If Avraham found resolution with Avimelek, there is still the outstanding issue of his and Sarah's sin against Hagar. How can Avraham mediate God's blessing to the nations if he and his wife are in fact abusers of the immigrant in their midst? It is to this that the narrative now turns in [Genesis 22](#).

Reflection Question

Based on Genesis 21:14-34, what does it look like for God's family to act as a blessing to the nations?